



IARSLCE 2026

International Association for Research on
Service-Learning and Community Engagement

🕒 Sun, Oct 11 · 9:00 – 11:30

PRE-CONFERENCE WORKSHOP

Participatory AI for Community Engagement

Nicholas Mattei & Saad Hassan

Tulane Center for Community-Engaged Artificial Intelligence

Sunday, October 11, 2026 · 9:00 – 11:30 am
Monroe Hall 152, Tulane University, New Orleans



Tulane University
Center for Community-Engaged
Artificial Intelligence

Welcome

AI

Design

Reflect

Share

Break

Breakouts

Report

Debrief

Today's plan

🕒 9:00 – 9:10 · 10 min

9:00	Welcome and introductions	Nick & Saad
9:10	What is AI, and where are we?	Nick
9:25	Designing with, not for	Saad
9:40	Reflect: your one problem	Everyone
9:55	Share-outs	Everyone
10:10	Break	We cluster your ideas
10:25	Breakout groups: three rounds	Two groups
11:10	Report back	Each group
11:20	Debrief and next steps	Everyone



Slides, readings, and links

saadh.info/pace2

Introductions

🕒 9:00 – 9:10 · 10 min



nickmattei.net

Nicholas Mattei

Associate Professor of Computer Science, Tulane University
Co-Director, Tulane Center for Community-Engaged AI

- AI, machine learning, and decision making with real-world stakeholders
- Community projects across New Orleans: civic tech, courts, utilities
- Co-author, Computing and Technology Ethics: Engaging Through Science Fiction (MIT Press)

Chair, ACM SIGAI

NSF CAREER

Prev. NASA · IBM · UNSW

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Introductions

🕒 9:00 – 9:10 · 10 min



saadh.info
saadh.info/a11y

Saad Hassan

Assistant Professor of Computer Science, Tulane University
Director, NOLA A11y Lab · Affiliate, Tulane CEAI

- Human–AI systems that make communication, information, and public services accessible
- Sign language and captioning technologies with Deaf and hard-of-hearing communities
- Civic AI and accessibility dashboards with community organizations

PhD, RIT

Visiting: Google & Meta

CHI · ASSETS

FUNDED BY

NSF

LA Board of Regents

Let's get to know you

🕒 9:00 – 9:10 · 10 min

1

Your name

and how you'd like to be called

2

Your affiliation

institution, office, or organization

3

One word about AI

how you feel about it right now

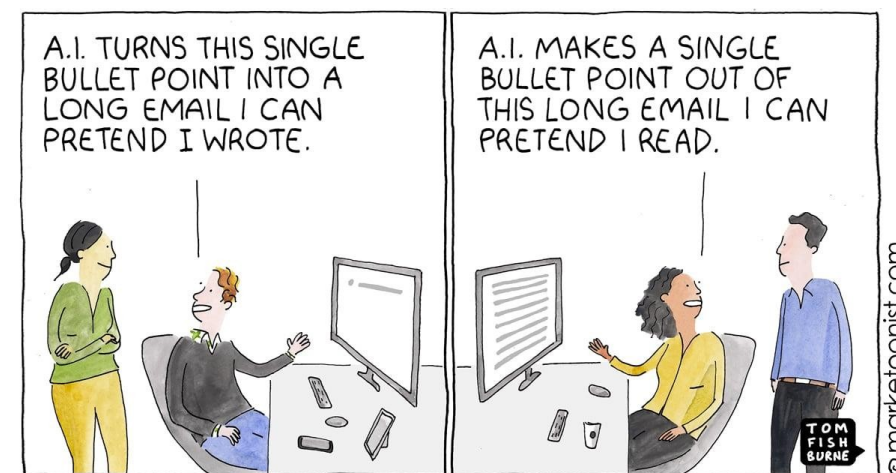
About 30 seconds each

The pre-workshop survey covers the rest, so keep it short.

PART 1

What is AI, and where are we?

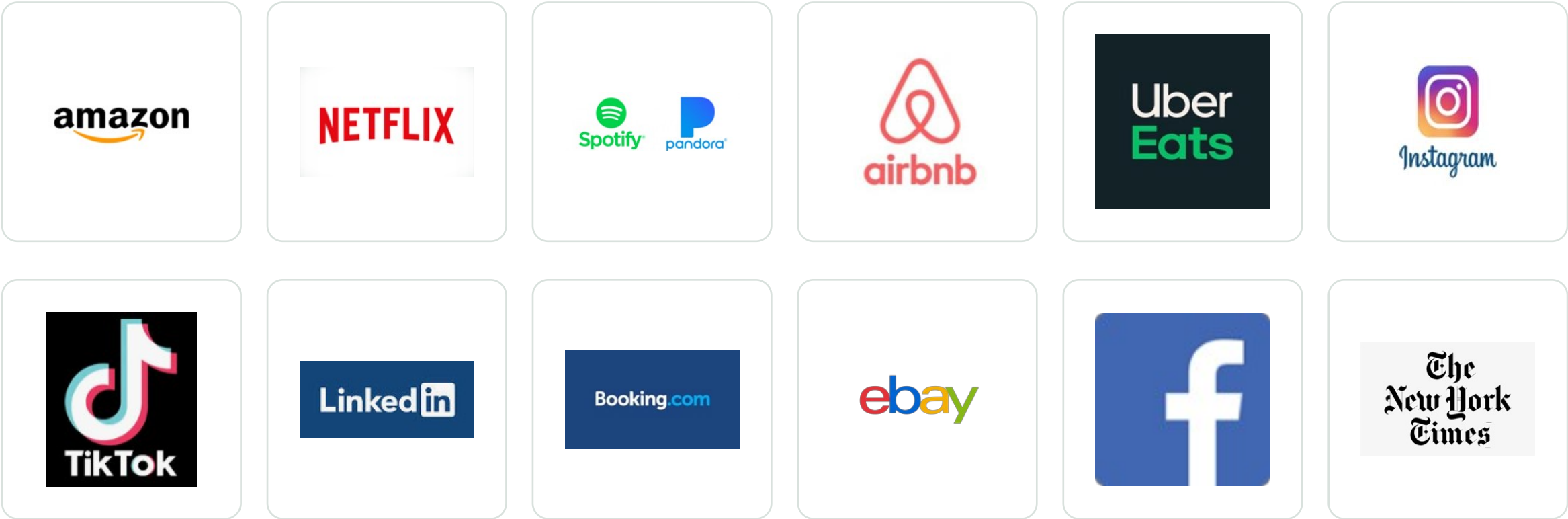
Nicholas Mattei



AI is already everywhere

🕒 9:10 – 9:25 · 15 min

Feeds, search, prices, matches, rides, loans: most of it has run on AI for years.



Three ways to tell a computer what to do

🕒 9:10 – 9:25 · 15 min

1

Traditional programming

The computer does exactly what you tell it, whether you meant it or not.

Rules written by people

2

Machine learning

Learns patterns from data to predict, classify, and recommend.

Rules learned from data

3

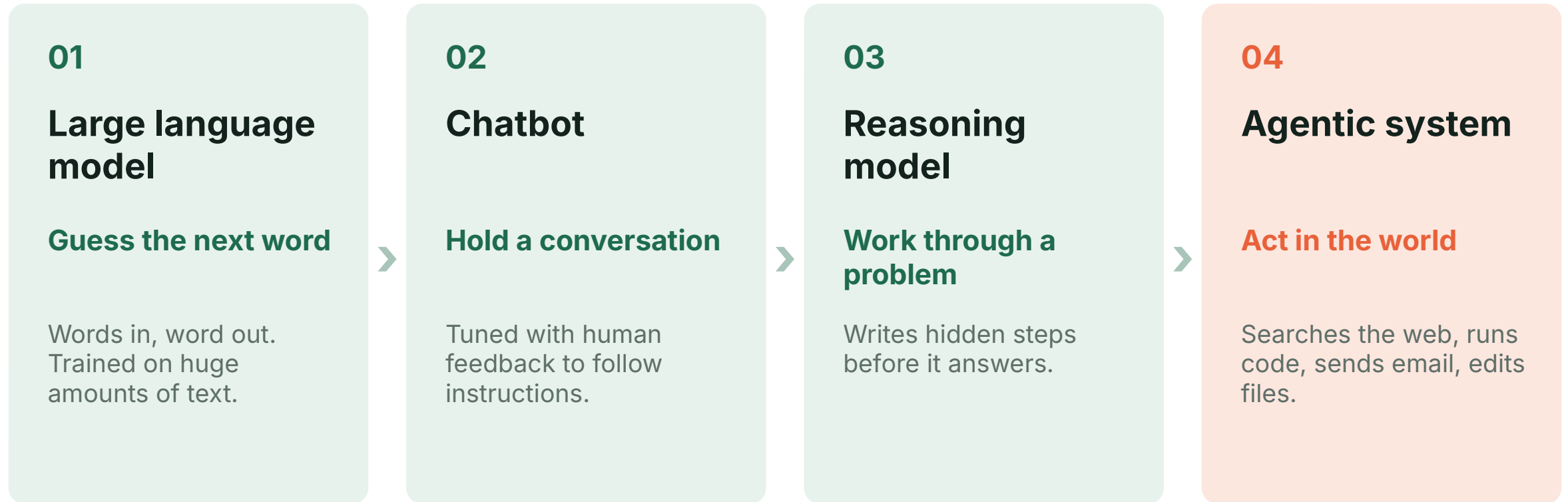
Generative AI

Trained broadly to do many things. Wonderful new behavior, but hard to predict exactly.

Text, images, code on demand

From autocomplete to agents

🕒 9:10 – 9:25 · 15 min



Each step adds capability, and each step adds new ways to fail.

The good, the bad, and the ugl-AI

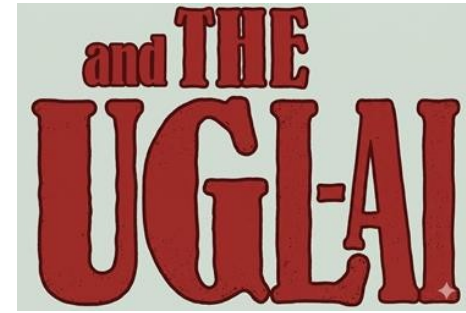
🕒 9:10 – 9:25 · 15 min



- Protein structure prediction (AlphaFold)
- Real progress on language tasks



- Rising electricity costs
- Copyright and intellectual property



- Question answering, but it makes things up
- Study aid, but it can block learning
- Companionship, but people can spiral

Fluent, confident, and wrong

🕒 9:10 – 9:25 · 15 min

AR

Can you tell me about the Provost of Tulane University?



As of my knowledge cutoff date of September 2021, the Provost of Tulane University was Dr. Robin Forman. The Provost is the chief academic officer of the university and is responsible for overseeing all academic programs, faculty appointments and promotions, and research initiatives.

Dr. Forman was appointed as Tulane University's 17th Provost in 2010, and he has also served as a professor of political science at the university since 1988. Prior to his appointment as Provost, Dr. Forman served as the Dean of the School of Liberal Arts at Tulane University and was instrumental in leading the school's recovery and rebuilding efforts following Hurricane Katrina in 2005.

As Provost, Dr. Forman has focused on enhancing Tulane's academic programs and research initiatives, as well as promoting interdisciplinary collaboration across the university. He has also worked to expand Tulane's global engagement and community partnerships, with a particular focus on New Orleans and the Gulf Coast region.

Ask a chatbot about Tulane's provost and you get a detailed, polished biography, with details that are made up.

Often called “hallucination.” Nick avoids the word: it anthropomorphizes a random number generator.

Check every output. Test, test, and test again.

What's at stake, right here in New Orleans

🕒 9:10 – 9:25 · 15 min

EXCLUSIVE

Police secretly monitored New Orleans with facial recognition cameras

Following records requests from The Post, officials paused the first known, widespread live facial recognition program used by police in the United States.

May 19, 2025

🔊 18 min

🔖

📌

💬 635

by [Ali Winston](#)
Illustrations by Garrett Board
and Alex Claudio
Feb 27, 2018, 2:25 PM CST

🔗

📧

📧

🗨️ Comments

Palantir has secretly been using New Orleans to test its predictive policing technology

Palantir deployed a predictive policing system in New Orleans that even city council members don't know about

If you buy something from a Verge link, the Verge may earn a commission. [See our ethics statement.](#)

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NPR 24 Hour Program Stream
On Air Now

HOURLY NEWS · LISTEN LIVE · MY PLAYLIST

TECHNOLOGY

Live cameras are tracking faces in New Orleans. Who should control them?

DECEMBER 16, 2025 · 4:29 AM ET

HEARD ON MORNING EDITION

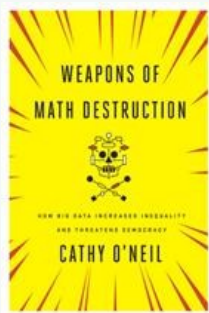
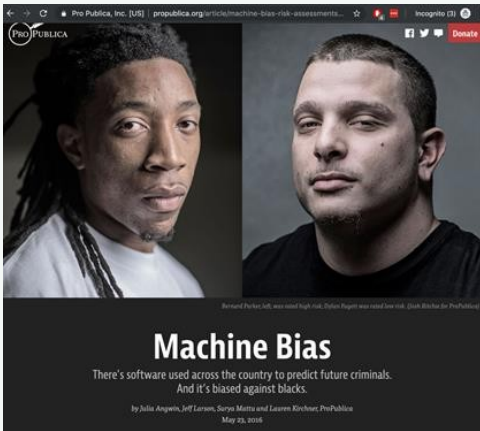
👤

Martin Kaste

Facial recognition and predictive policing were tested on New Orleans residents, often without public knowledge.

Automated decisions of consequence

🕒 9:10 – 9:25 · 15 min



ProPublica, Machine Bias (2016)
O'Neil, Weapons of Math Destruction (2016)

Hiring

A recruiting tool learned to downgrade women's résumés and was scrapped.

Advertising

Searching Black-identifying names surfaced more ads for arrest records.

Lending

Credit models can reproduce historical patterns of exclusion.

Policing and sentencing

Risk scores shape bail and sentencing decisions.



How can academia collaborate outside the ivory tower to solve problems using AI?

Illustration: Melania Bianucci, Ludicomix

A community-led research pipeline

🕒 9:10 – 9:25 · 15 min



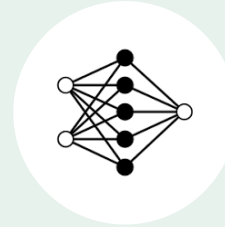
Community workshops

Learn from the community. Build relationships with non-profits.



Service-learning capstones

Year-long student projects with partners. Working prototypes.



Research teams

Faculty from CS, sociology, economics, public health.



Joint funding

Seed funds, then shared grants with partners as co-PIs.



Tulane University
Center for Community-Engaged
Artificial Intelligence

sse.tulane.edu/cs/ceai

LLMs for city government

🕒 9:10 – 9:25 · 15 min

EXAMPLE 1 with Eye on Surveillance

THE CHALLENGE

City Council meetings are hours long and hard for residents to search.

WHAT WE BUILT

SAWT: ask a question, get answers drawn from council meeting records.

LEARN MORE

sawt.us

SAWT beta

[About](#) [How to use](#) [Feedback](#)

What is New Orleans City Council doing about

crime?

Get answer from Sawt

This tool is under active development. Responses may be inaccurate. [Learn more](#)

#1: Regular City Council Meeting 4/20/2023

9 years ago



Watch on  YouTube

#2: Regular Council Meeting

9 months ago



Watch on  YouTube

REGGIE: searchable utility meetings

🕒 9:10 – 9:25 · 15 min

EXAMPLE 2

with Entergy

THE CHALLENGE

Public Service Commission meetings: 5 jurisdictions, 5+ hour videos every month.

WHAT WE BUILT

REGGIE, a chatbot that indexes public meetings for question answering.

IMPACT

PSC research went from hours to minutes.
Best CS Project, Tulane Capstone Expo.



AI for monitoring criminal court

EXAMPLE 3

with Court Watch NOLA

THE PARTNER

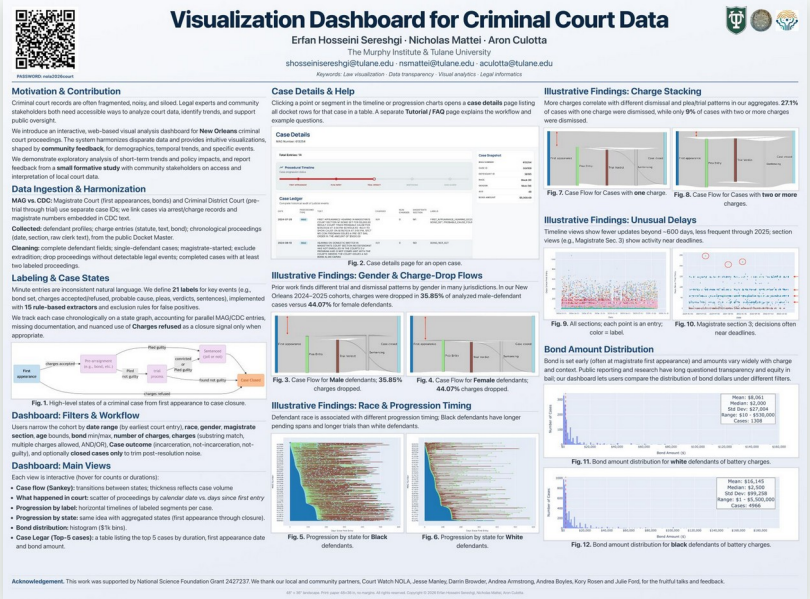
Since 2007, trained volunteers have observed Orleans Parish criminal court.

STARTED SMALL

Student-built data infrastructure for 100K+ cases over 15 years.

GREW INTO

An NSF-funded program: anomaly detection and LLM tools for defendants, victims, and attorneys.



Fairness in microloan discovery

🕒 9:10 – 9:25 · 15 min

EXAMPLE 4

with Kiva.org

THE PARTNER

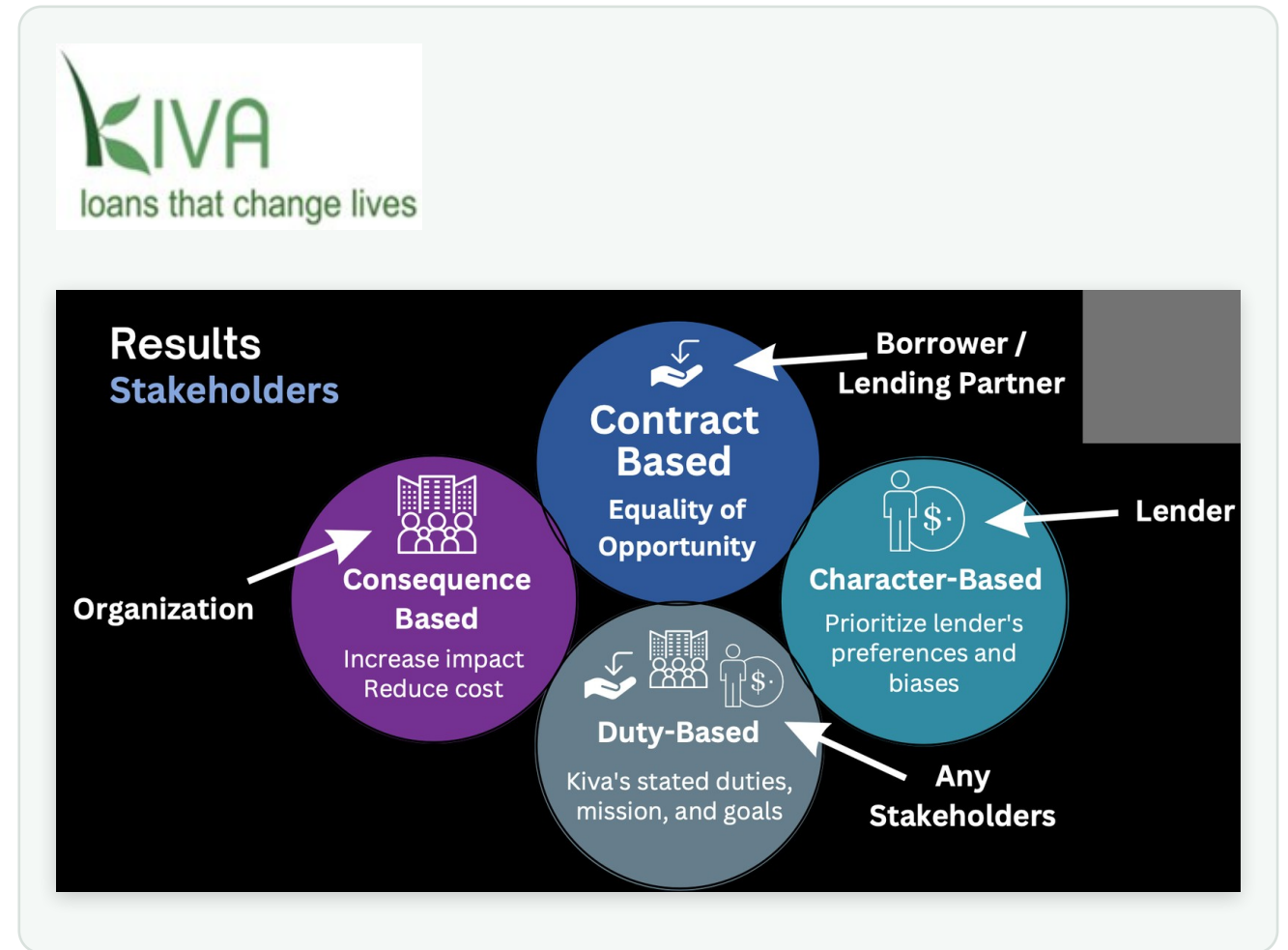
Kiva crowdfunds microloans: \$1.74B to 4.3M borrowers in 77 countries (2022).

THE CHALLENGE

Lender attention is uneven, so some borrowers get overlooked.

WHAT WE STUDIED

Recommendations that balance fairness across borrowers, lenders, and Kiva's mission.



Good practices we've learned

🕒 9:10 – 9:25 · 15 min

1 Start with conversations

Outreach and ideation meetings, with help from your public service office.

2 Start small

Data prep, websites, capstone-sized projects. Early wins build trust.

3 Share the money and the credit

Partners as co-PIs. Budget for their time.

4 Plan for years, not semesters

Hand work off between student cohorts.

5 Listen deeply

Including about when not to use AI.

“Not a pipeline in which communities supply problems that are appropriated by academics.”

Culotta & Mattei, Service Learning for Community-Centered AI Research

PART 2

Designing with, not for

Saad Hassan

NOLA A11y Lab · saadh.info/a11y

Affiliate, Tulane Center for Community-Engaged AI



CEAI community workshop on AI risks and benefits, April 2023

What is design?

🕒 9:25 – 9:40 · 15 min

"The transformation of existing conditions into preferred ones."

Herbert Simon, 1969

Preferred by whom?

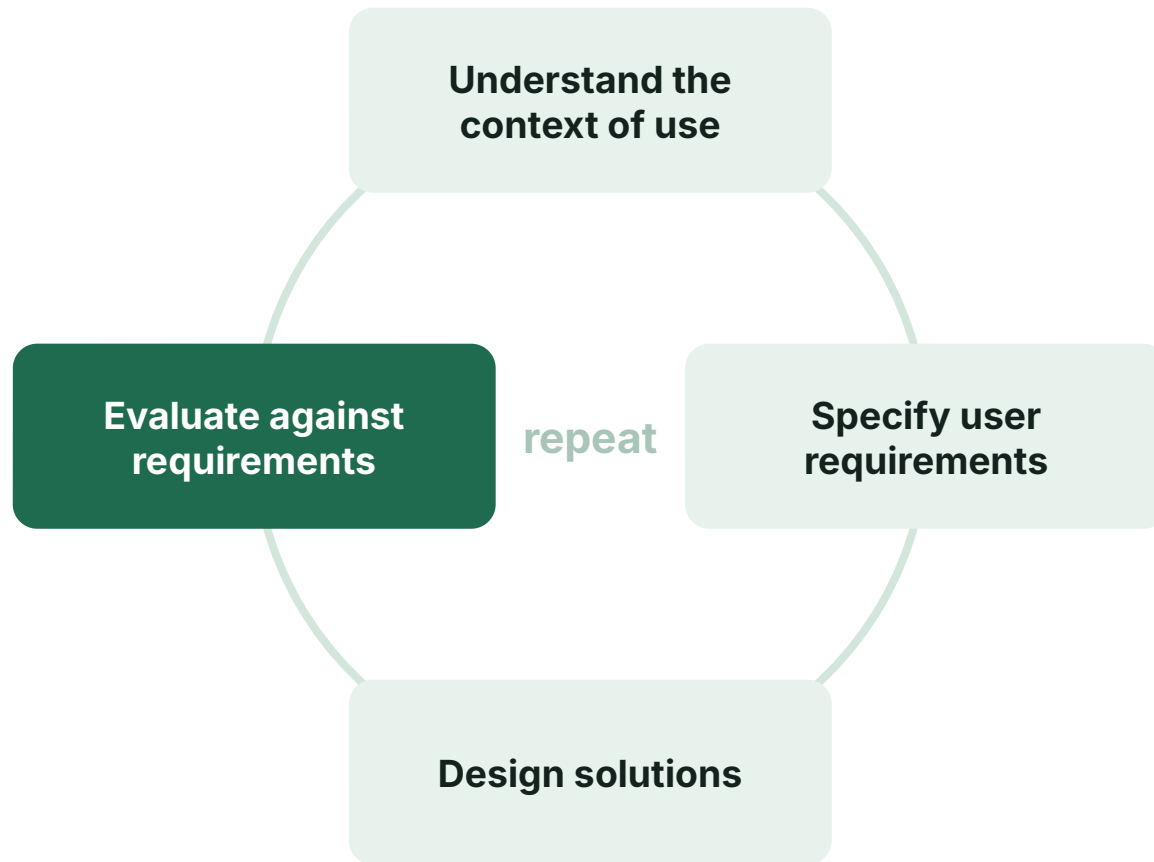
Community problems are wicked problems: requirements conflict or are unknown, and there is no single correct answer (Rittel & Webber, 1973).

Widen the sidewalks, and traffic shifts onto the streets.



User-centered design (UCD)

🕒 9:25 – 9:40 · 15 min



Early and continual focus on users, measurement of real use, and iterative design.

Norman & Draper, 1986

The limitation

Users are studied and tested with, but designers still decide what counts as a requirement. Power stays with the design team.

Human-centered design (HCD)

🕒 9:25 – 9:40 · 15 min

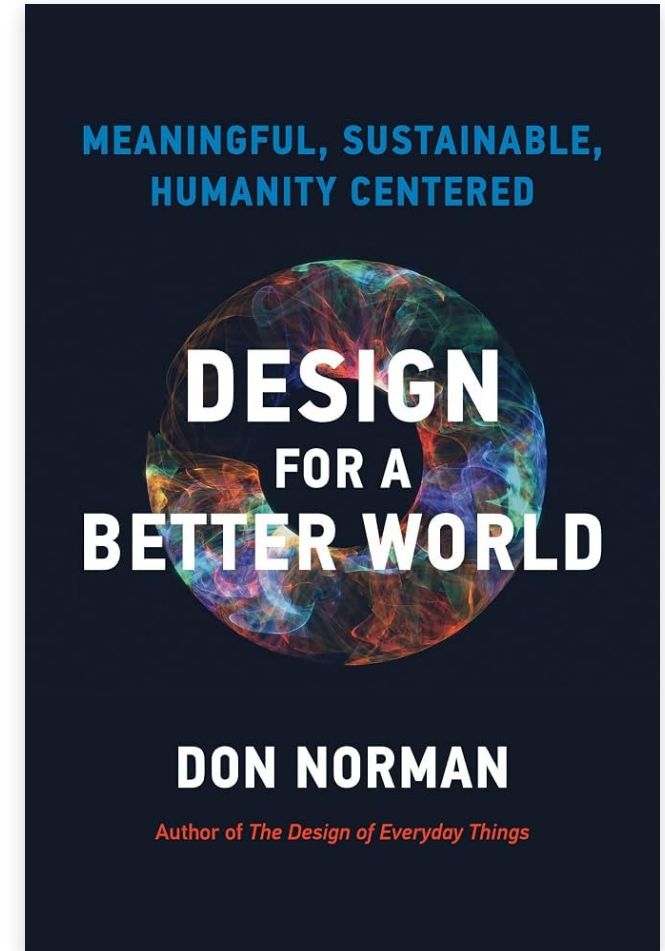
Widens the lens from users to people, communities, and the systems around them.

1 Immersion

2 Solve the root problem

3 Think in systems

4 Iterate, small and often



Two warnings from the research

🕒 9:25 – 9:40 · 15 min

Is empathy enough?

Simulating disability (for example, wearing a blindfold) can lend false confidence and lead to wrong conclusions.

Bennett & Rosner, "The Promise of Empathy: Design, Disability, and Knowing the 'Other'," CHI 2019

Is a seat at the table enough?

Bringing people into the room does not mean they have, or see themselves as having, full status and authority.

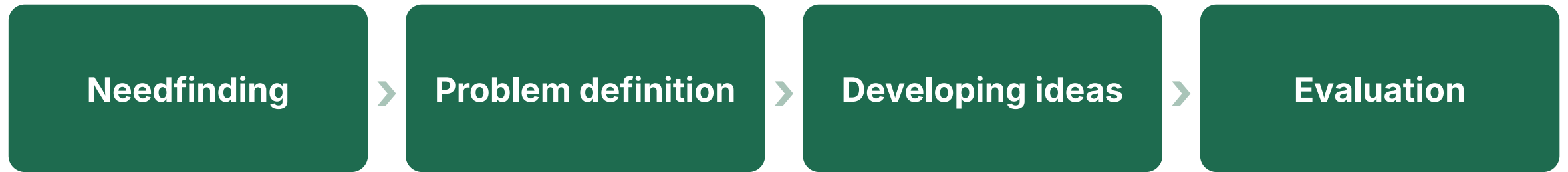
Harrington, Erete & Piper, "Deconstructing Community-Based Collaborative Design," CSCW 2019

Participatory design (PD)

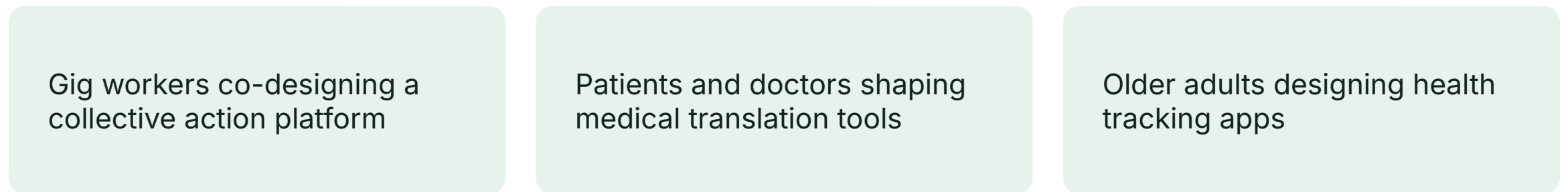
🕒 9:25 – 9:40 · 15 min

De-centers the designer. Stakeholders share decisions in every phase.

Schuler & Namioka, 1993



EXAMPLES



Between Scylla and Charybdis

🕒 9:25 – 9:40 · 15 min



The Odyssey (Universal Pictures, 2025)

Too few voices

"You should have included group X." A design that misses the mark.

Too many, with no stopping point

Is there an ethical point to stop adding voices and still make decisions?

Where can communities shape AI?

🕒 9:25 – 9:40 · 15 min

1

Problem framing

What should we work on?

2

Data

Whose data, collected how?

3

Design

What does it look like?

4

Evaluation

Who decides it works?

5

Governance

Who deploys and oversees it?

And the question before all of these:

Should AI be used here at all?

Sign language as text entry

🕒 9:25 – 9:40 · 15 min

EXAMPLE 1

Deaf signers

THE IDEA

Sign wherever you would type: search, messages, voice assistants.

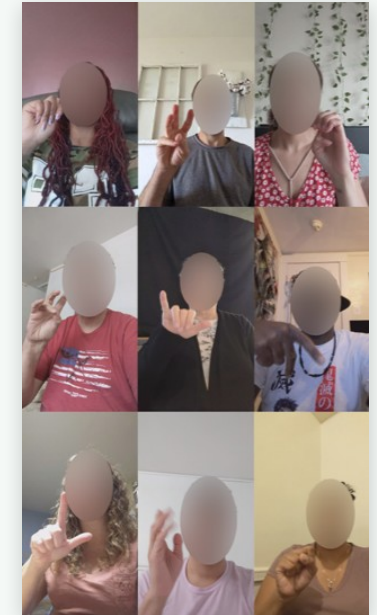
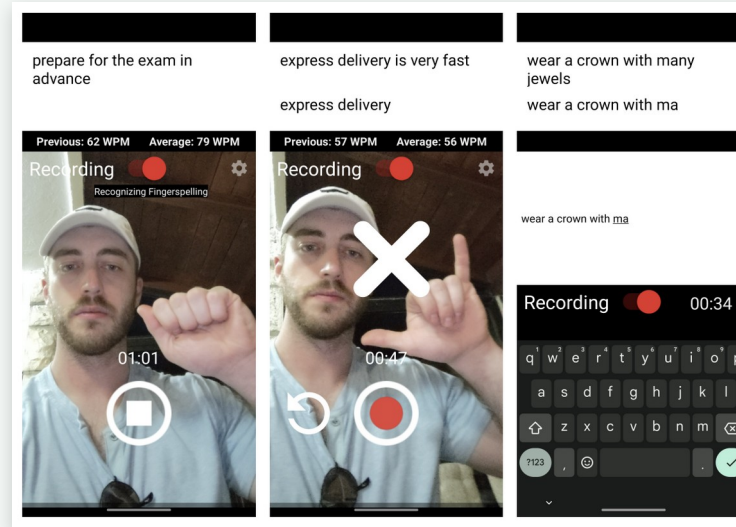
OUR WORK

ASL input methods for phones (MobileHCI 2023) and the FSboard fingerspelling dataset (CVPR 2025), with Google.

NOW SHIPPING

Google's SL2T brings ASL dictation to Gboard and Live Transcribe on Pixel 11 (August 2026).

deepmind.google/blog/putting-sign-language-ai-into-users-hands



"We believe in building with the Deaf community, not just for it."

Google DeepMind, August 2026

Sign language learning

🕒 9:25 – 9:40 · 15 min

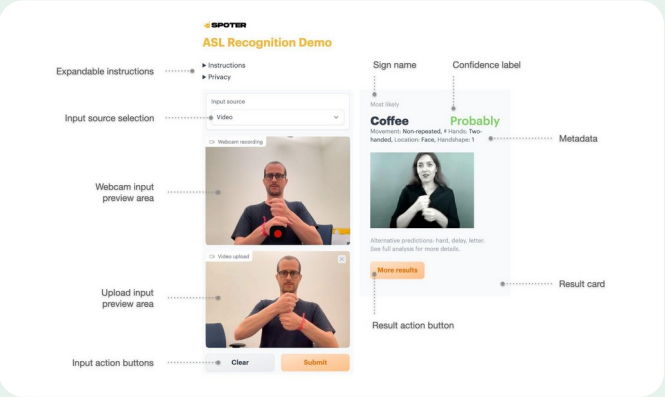
EXAMPLE 2

Supporting a disability community means supporting the people with disabilities and the people around them.



Hearing parents

Learning to sign with their Deaf children



New signers

Looking up unfamiliar signs by video (CHI 2022, ASSETS 2022)



Healthcare providers

Communicating with Deaf patients (ASSETS 2025)

Captions that carry emotion

🕒 9:25 – 9:40 · 15 min

EXAMPLE 3

Deaf & hard-of-hearing viewers

THE CHALLENGE

Captions drop tone of voice: how something is said, not just what.

HOW IT WORKS

Slice speech word by word, estimate the emotion of each word, and show it in the caption or as vibration.

PUBLISHED

CHI 2024 (Honorable Mention), ASSETS 2024, CHI 2025



Civic AI with community organizations

🕒 9:25 – 9:40 · 15 min

EXAMPLE 4

What civic and disability advocates told us

"If I could ask, 'Give me a list of all ADA sidewalk problems on North State Street between X and Y,' and it answered accurately and verifiably, that would be game-changing."

"The tool is only as good as the software developers. If they have no background in the ADA or in issues related to disabilities, their questions will sometimes omit significant areas of knowledge."

WHAT WE WANT TO DO

Design civic AI that connects residents, communities, and local governments.

- Answers people can verify, linked to local records
- A clear path to a person when AI falls short
- Built with disability advocates and civic groups from the start

NSF award, 2026 · Saad Hassan, PI

Your one problem

🕒 9:40 – 10:10 · 30 min

Pick one community engagement challenge where AI could help, hurt, create barriers, or lower them.

- 1

The problem

One sentence
- 2

Who is affected

Partners, students, residents
- 3

Where AI might help

Even a little
- 4

Where AI worries you

Risks, harms, trust
- 5

Who isn't at the table yet

Voices to bring in

○

Circle

the one line you most want to dig into: a hope or a worry.

Share in 1–2 sentences

Your problem, plus what you circled. Sticky note goes on the wall.

9:40 · 15 min to write

9:55 · 15 min to share

Break

15

minutes

Back at 10:25

While you're away

- 1 We group your sticky notes into 2–4 shared themes
- 2 Each theme becomes a breakout starting point
- 3 Add another sticky note if something new comes up

Breakout groups and share-outs

🕒 10:25 – 11:20 · 55 min

Group A · AI lens
with Nick

Group B · Design lens
with Saad

Pick the group closest to your problem.

10:25

15 min

Elaborate the problem

Add context on sticky notes. What's really going on?

10:40

15 min

Who else belongs in this conversation?

Partners and community members you could bring in.

10:55

15 min

Limits of AI

Where should human agency stay? Where does human-centered work stand after AI?

11:10

Share out: 5 min per group. One problem, one partner to bring in, one line AI shouldn't cross.

Debrief

🕒 11:20 – 11:30 · 10 min

1 One idea you'll take home

2 One person or partner you'll bring in

3 What follow-up would help you?



saadh.info/pace2

nsmattei@tulane.edu · saadhassan@tulane.edu

Thank you!